App Intents & Apple Intelligence: Enhance App Experience

Riswana Deval · Follow · 3 min read · Sep 26, 2025

App Intents Blog Series

To make things easier, we've put together a series of blogs that will walk you step-by-step from understanding App Intents to actually integrating them into your app.

1. **Basic Understanding** (this blog) — A beginner's guide to App Intents, how they can enhance your apps, and what's new in WWDC25.
2. Hands-on with App Intents: Journal App Integration (Up Next)
3. Hands-on with App Intents: Coding Spotlight, Widgets, Gestures & Beyond (Up Next)

Now Let's jump in and level up your app!

App Intents

App Intents focuses on making app features more discoverable and usable outside of the app itself — via Shortcuts, Siri, Spotlight, the Action Button, Widgets, etc.

Instead of your app functioning like a closed box, App Intents let you expose specific actions so users can:

- Ask Siri to run them
- Find them in **Spotlight** Search
- Trigger them with the **Action Button**
- Run them as part of a **Shortcut**
- See them inside **Widgets**

Since their launch in iOS 16, App Intents have significantly improved. With Apple Intelligence, these integrations become even more powerful. And the support for App Intents with Siri from iOS 18.4 is something I was really looking forward to!

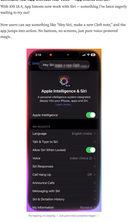
And it's not just about Siri — many other great features in App Intents can make your app's features and content easily accessible across the Apple ecosystem. Below are details that can show how you can enhance your app:

Direct Access to Core Features

With **App Intents**, users can jump straight into your app's most important actions via App Shortcuts — no need to open the app at all.

This enhances user convenience and encourages more frequent engagement with your app's core features.

For example, in our App — Cloth AI, you don't need to open the app to start a new note recording — just run tap with App Shortcuts and you're good to go.



App Intents, Siri Shortcuts, Spotlight, and Apple Intelligence integrations.

It's that simple — frequent actions become accessible with a single tap!

To start, look for everyday actions users can do without opening the app — things they do often. Turning those into shortcuts can really save time and make the whole experience smoother and faster.

Command Your App with Just Your Voice — App Intents with Siri

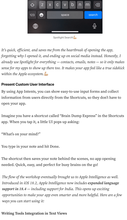
With iOS 16.4, App Intents now work with Siri — something I've been eagerly waiting to try out!

Now users can say something like "Hey Siri, make a new Cloth note," and the app jumps into action. No buttons, no screens, just pure voice-powered magic.

Siri Settings, Shortcuts, App Intents and Apple Intelligence

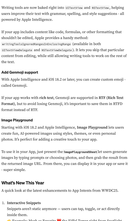
Search Within the App Without Opening It: Spotlight Search

App Intents let users search your app's content right from Spotlight — no need to open the app at all.



Spotlight Search, App Intents and Apple Intelligence

For example, in Cloth AI, if someone types "Meeting notes" or "Grocery list" in Spotlight, the matching notes just show up.



Spotlight Search, App Intents and Apple Intelligence

It's quick, efficient, and saves users the hassle/trouble of opening the app. Forgetting why I opened it, and ending up on social media instead. Honestly, I already use Spotlight for everything — contacts, emails, notes — so it's only makes sense for my apps to show up there too. It makes your app feel like a true citizen within the Apple ecosystem.

Present Custom User Interface

By using App Intents, you can show easy-to-use input forms and collect information from users directly from the Shortcuts, so they don't have to open your app.

Imagine you have a shortcut called "Brain Dump Expense" in the Shortcuts app. When you tap it, a little UI pops up asking:

"What's on your mind?"

You type in your note and hit Done.

The shortcut then saves your note behind the scenes, no app opening needed. Quick, easy, and perfect for busy bosses on the go!

The flow of the workshop eventually brought us to Apple Intelligence as well. Introduced in iOS 18.1, Apple Intelligence now includes **expanded language support in iOS 18.4** *— including support for Italian. This opens up exciting opportunities to make your app even smarter and more helpful. Here are a few ways you can start using it:*

Writing Tools Integration in Text Views

Writing tools are now baked right into `UITextView` and `NSTextView`, helping users improve their text with grammar, spelling, and style suggestions — all powered by Apple Intelligence.

If your app includes content like code, formulas, or other formatting that shouldn't be edited, Apple provides a handy method: `setWritingToolsAppropriateUntil(range: NSRange)` in both `UITextDelegate` and `NSTextDelegate`. It lets you skip that particular content from editing, while still allowing writing tools to work on the rest of the text.

Add Genmoji support

With Apple Intelligence and iOS 18.2+ later, you can create custom emoji — called Genmoji.

If your app works with **rich text**, Genmoji are supported in **iOS (Rich Text Format)**, but to avoid losing Genmoji, it's important to save them in RTFD format instead of RTF.

Image Playground

Starting with iOS 18.2 and Apple Intelligence, **Image Playground** lets users create fun, AI-powered images using styles, themes, or even personal photos. It's perfect for adding a creative touch to your app.

To use it in your app, just present the `ImagePlaygroundSheet` users generate images by typing prompts or choosing photos, and then grab the result from the returned image URL. From there, you can display it in your app or save it — super simple.

What's New This Year

A quick look at the latest enhancements to App Intents from WWDC25.

1. **Interactive Snippets**
   Snippets aren't static anymore — users can tap, toggle, or act directly inside them.
   ✅ Example: Mark as Favorite ❤️ for Eiffel Tower right from Spotlight, and the snippet updates instantly.
2. **Image Search & Visual Intelligence**
   Your app's results can now appear in system image searches, and the system can suggest results from your app.
   ✅ Example: Highlight 🔆 Sydney Opera House in a photo → Spotlight shows your app's entry.
3. **Invoke Actions via Shortcuts**
   On watchOS, Spotlight can run actions directly with App Shortcuts.
   ✅ Example: Type "Send Message" → instantly trigger your app's shortcut without opening it.
4. **Smarter Entities**
   `IndexedEntity` makes properties searchable, while `OpenIntent` deep-links results.
   ✅ Example: Type "Book" → Spotlight suggests all bookmarks tagged with Arts from your app.
5. **Undoable Intents & Choices**
   iOS 26 adds undo support and more than you've choices.
   ✅ Example: When deleting a collection → either "Delete" or "Archive." If deleted by mistake, a three-finger swipe gesture instantly undoes it.
6. **Foreground & Background Modes**
   Control whether an intent opens your app or stays lightweight in the background.
   ✅ Example: Ask Siri, "What's the Eiffel Tower crowd status?" → get an answer without opening the app.
7. **Convenience APIs**
   Developers also get some handy **new macros** and APIs to reduce boilerplate code.
   New macros like `@AcceptableValues` and `@Unpackaged` cut boilerplate.
8. **Easier Packaging**
   App Intents can live inside Swift Packages or static libraries, making modular architecture easier.
   Share the same intents on iOS, watchOS, and macOS without duplicating code.

By integrating **App Intents** and tapping into the latest Apple Intelligence features, you can make your app more **interactive, smart,** and tightly woven into the Apple ecosystem.

Take a moment to think about where these features could fit in your app — whether it's spotlight search, writing tools, or voice-command with siri — and make your app experience more seamless and delightful.

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